

THE LAST GREAT PHARAOH

OSIRIS RISING

B. C. ARSENIOS



• Troy

• Mycenae

AEGEAN
SEA

Crete
(Keftiu)

MEDITERRANEAN
(THE GREAT G)

LIBU



— Approximate extent of
Egyptian power and influence
(c. 1200 BCE)

0 125 250 375 500
Stadia



HATTI

Carchemish

Ugarit

Cyprus
(Alashiya)

Byblos

Sidon

Tyre

Kadesh

Megiddo

Joppa

CANAAN

Gaza

Ashkelon

NILE DELTA

Per-Sopdu

Pi-Ramesses

Heliopolis

Memphis

Abydos

Thebes

Aswan

RED SEA

NUBIA

AN SEA
(GREEN)

THE NINETEENTH DYNASTY

The World of The Last Great Pharaoh

The Nineteenth Dynasty ruled Egypt during a golden age of power, monument building, and imperial reach.



RAMSESSES I

Founder of the Dynasty
Pharaoh



SETI I

Great Builder and Warrior
Pharaoh



RAMSESSES II

Ramesses the Great
Pharaoh



MERNEPTAH

Pharaoh · Great Conqueror
Son of Ramesses II



AMENMESSE

Rival Claimant
Contested
Lineage



SETI II

Pharaoh
Son of Merneptah



**TWOSRET
(TAWOSRET)**

Great Royal Wife
Queen

Daughter of Merneptah

Parentage uncertain;
line of succession
contested in the
late years of the
dynasty.



SIPTAH

Young King
Uncertain Lineage



**TWOSRET
(TAWOSRET)**

Pharaoh
Last Ruler of the
Nineteenth Dynasty
Daughter of Merneptah



LEGEND	
	Direct Succession
	Marriage / Queenship
	Contested Lineage
	Rival / Contested Claimant

A NOTE ON HISTORY

Osiris Rising is a work of historical fiction inspired by real people, places, conflicts, and events at the end of Egypt's Nineteenth Dynasty and during the collapse of the Late Bronze Age. Where the historical record survives, I have followed it closely. Where it falls silent, contradicts itself, or leaves only fragments, I have imagined one possible path through what remains.

Some characters and relationships have been reconstructed or invented for the story. The larger world they inhabit—and the upheaval overtaking it—was real.

Inspired by history. Built within its silences.

THE LAST GREAT PHARAOH

Osiris Rising



CHAPTER I

Memphis Refuses



CHAPTER II

No Man Defies the Throne



CHAPTER III

The Crown Calls Its Swords



CHAPTER IV

The Rebel Prepares



CHAPTER V

The Hand Closes



CHAPTER VI

The God's House



CHAPTER VII

Blood at Ptah



CHAPTER VIII

The Fall of Memphis



CHAPTER IX

The Savior of the White Walls



CHAPTER X

The Queen's Fear



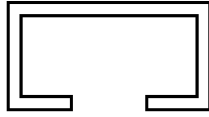
CHAPTER XI

The Empty Throne



CHAPTER XII

The Coronation



CHAPTER I

Memphis Refuses

Ra's barque burned at the western edge of the world, where Nut waited to swallow the sun. Across the Red Land below, a caravan crawled eastward toward Memphis, its men and animals small beneath the darkening heavens. At its head walked a scarred Sherden giant carrying a horned helmet beneath one arm. The Egyptians called him Akir, though no two of them shaped the foreign name alike. The road was little more than two parallel scars pressed into the Red Land by generations of hooves and wooden wheels. Heat still rose from the sand, carrying the smell of hot stone. To the east, where Memphis lay beyond the horizon, the darkening sky held a faint stain that might have been cultivated land or only the promise of it.

The caravan carried twenty or so animals burdened with sealed wine jars, baskets of natron, rolled hides, dried fruit, and salt. Two calves acquired at the western station protested every step.

"He weighed the silver twice," Sennefer said for the fourth time since midday.

The caravan master rode a small gray donkey because his left knee no longer trusted long distances. Near fifty and broad through the belly, he had traveled for Neset's house for sixteen years without losing a shipment.

"You weighed it three times," Nakht answered.

"Because he weighed it twice," Sennefer replied.

Nakht walked beside the third string of animals, one hand upon the leather case containing his writing board and the account of every measure exchanged. His wife had wrapped it in extra linen after their daughter once spilled beer across a tax record. Nakht had checked the case more often than the knife at his waist.

"Abdi-Milku always weighs everything twice," Nakht said. "The silver only offended you because you did not plan to lose it."

Sennefer twisted in the saddle. “He did not need to weigh my silver twice after all these years of trading.”

Nakht adjusted the writing case beneath his arm. “It was Neset’s silver. Why do you care how often he weighed it?”

“Because the price changed after we arrived,” Sennefer said. “To keep the shipment whole, I agreed the difference would come from my journey payment. My daughter marries before the next moon, and Abdi-Milku has taken half the silver meant for her wedding bed.”

Penthu looked up from the rear rope. His first journey west had stripped most of the excitement from him. “She will still have a bed. You complain too much to let a merchant take the whole thing.”

“When you have paid for a daughter’s wedding,” Sennefer answered, “you may tell me how much complaining is enough.”

Menna laughed from farther back. The widowed old handler walked beside a brown jenny called Nebet, though he usually addressed her as Lady Trouble. His pay fed his dead brother’s widow and three children. “Sennefer, the boy has sisters,” Menna said. “He already knows every wedding reaches into some man’s purse.”

Penthu touched the small bundle beneath his sash to make certain the dates he had hidden for his mother and sisters were still there. “Even Lady Trouble complains less than Sennefer.”

Nebet brayed as though summoned into the argument.

“She heard you,” Menna said. “You had better sleep away from the animals tonight.”

Masaharta, a Libyan veteran hired to protect the caravan, walked on Akir’s right. He was thin as a spear shaft, with tattooed lines at his temples and pale eyes that seemed never to moisten. His gaze moved constantly over the ground and low ridges.

“Abdi-Milku did not cheat you,” he said.

Sennefer made a disgusted sound. "At last, the desert offers an opinion."

"He learned what you wanted, named a price, and watched you pay it," Masaharta said. "That is trade."

"He demanded silver after agreeing to grain and linen," Sennefer countered.

Masaharta nodded toward Nakht. "Because you let Abdi-Milku hear that the warehouse scribes in Memphis know the estate marks on the wine jars."

Nakht looked offended. "I was warning my clerk not to falsify the inventory."

"And Abdi-Milku realized that jars bearing marks Memphis trusted were worth more," Masaharta said. "A merchant hears profit better than a priest hears sin."

The second Sherden, Bena, walked beside the lead animals with his shield across his back, rubbing a nick in his sword pommel with one thumb. "The Canaanite sold us good wine. If Sennefer dislikes the price, we can drink enough to make it seem fair."

Sennefer pointed at him. "If one seal is broken before we reach Neset's warehouse, I will sell your helmet to pay for it."

"You could not afford my helmet," Bena replied.

"After Abdi-Milku, I cannot afford sandals," Sennefer said.

The men were still laughing when Sennefer raised one hand. Akir stopped without asking why. Ahead, darkness gathered around a shallow depression where several tamarisks stood against the sky. Coarse grass and reeds followed the low ground toward an old stone-lined well. Three palms leaned eastward under years of western wind.

Sennefer exhaled with relief. "We stop there. The well is one day's journey from Memphis, and we will not find another before full dark."

Akir put on his helmet. "Bena, take the south side. Masaharta, take the north. Circle the watering place and make certain we are alone."

The two men slipped ahead while the caravan remained on open ground. Bena returned first and reported no one along the southern approach. Masaharta came back soon after, having found old dung, two sets of week-old sandal tracks, and nothing fresher. Only then did Akir allow the animals to descend.

Camp formed from practiced habit. Menna and Penthu watered the donkeys in measured turns while Sennefer inspected the lashings and Nakht checked the seals. Bena chose a place near the animals. Akir and Masaharta gathered palm fiber and dead tamarisk for a small fire.

They ate flatbread warmed over the flame, onions, dried fish, and dates Sennefer insisted had already been entered as caravan provisions. Penthu kept his private bundle hidden. Now that most of the road lay behind them, its hardships were safe enough to laugh about.

Masaharta stretched his legs toward the fire. "Sennefer was not the only man who left too much silver at the station."

Sennefer narrowed his eyes. "Whose silver are we discussing now?"

Masaharta smiled. "Mine. A Meshwesh woman at the beer house took most of it."

Bena laughed first. Penthu tried not to look interested and failed badly enough that Nakht noticed.

"Yes, you gave her enough to buy another donkey," Menna said.

"A donkey would not have kept me as warm." Masaharta lifted his cup. "That woman had an ass round enough to make a man forget which road led home."

Penthu choked on his bread. Sennefer slapped his back without taking his eyes from Masaharta.

"And what did this miracle of the western desert think of you?" Nakht asked.

"She drank my wine, took my silver, and laughed when I told her I could go all night."

“Could you?” Bena asked.

Masaharta drank before answering. “The night ended before I did.”

Disbelieving laughter erupted around the fire. Even Akir smiled.

Masaharta pointed his cup toward him. “Her cousin wanted the giant. Younger. Better breasts.”

“You examined them for me?” Akir asked.

“A friend should know what his friend refuses,” Masaharta replied.

Akir tore a piece of bread. “I have a wife in Memphis.”

Masaharta shook his head. “Memphis was four days away.”

“She would still know,” Akir said.

“Fear is a poor reason for loyalty,” Nakht said.

Akir looked at him. “My wife is more beautiful than any woman Masaharta must pay to call him strong.”

That drew a louder laugh, including from Masaharta. He accepted the blow with a raised cup. “Then keep your wife. I prefer women who take their silver and let me leave before breakfast.”

“That,” Menna said, “is because no woman has wanted you to stay for breakfast.”

Masaharta’s smile showed white in the firelight. “That is because I choose wisely.”

Their laughter faded with the last of the daylight, and one by one the men prepared for sleep. Nakht closed his writing case and tucked it safely beneath his head. Sennefer made a final round of the animals, telling anyone still awake that, if they held their pace, tomorrow’s moonrise would find them in Memphis. Menna settled beside Nebet and rested his back against the patient jenny’s flank. Bena stretched out near the dying fire, still arguing with Akir over the merits of western beer. They chose their place at the edge of the camp, their swords beside one hand and helmets beside the other. Penthu

placed his bag of dates beneath his head and fell asleep before the two Sherden finished their argument.

Masaharta took first watch. Once the voices around the fire faded, the desert settled into a stillness the cities never knew. The heat left the sand quickly, and cold air slipped through the reeds and beneath the linen at his shoulders. Above him, Nut stretched from one horizon to the other, her darkness crowded with stars. Masaharta ate roasted chickpeas one at a time, listening to the faint grinding of the donkeys' teeth, the small movement of water beneath the reeds, and the occasional crack from the dying fire. Out here, with nothing demanded of him but the watch, he found a peace that ordinary life rarely allowed.

Then Menna's donkey raised her head.

Masaharta watched her ears turn toward the northern scrub. There was no wind. A night bird lifted from a tamarisk beyond the well, flew only a short distance, and settled again. Beneath the sound of the reeds he heard stone touch stone once, lightly enough that a tired sentry might have mistaken it for cooling earth. He walked past the fire as though checking the animals. At the edge of the reeds he crouched beside a print that had not been there when he circled the well: the front of a sandal pressed into damp soil, its heel deliberately withheld to leave less sign. Masaharta looked toward Akir. The Sherden slept with one hand near his sword. Masaharta did not wake him. He loosened his knife, slipped into the reeds, and disappeared from the place where any watcher expected the sentry to remain.

The raiders had counted seven men in the caravan and recognized only three as professional fighters. Eight against three, with darkness and surprise, should have been enough. Two circled toward the animals, four crept toward the fire, and two waited to strike anyone who escaped. They wore patched hides and linen stiff with old sweat. One carried an Egyptian spear with a repaired shaft. Another had wrapped sacking around feet where his sandals had split. They had followed the

caravan since midday. Men without water could be chased; men beside water could be surrounded.

Akir woke when the fire collapsed inward. Masaharta would normally have fed it before it fell so low. Akir opened his eyes without moving his head. The flat stone beside the fire where Masaharta had been sitting was empty. He reached across the sand and closed one hand around Bena's ankle. The second Sherden woke with his hand already closing around his sword hilt. Akir touched two fingers to his own eyes, then pointed toward the animals. Bena nodded. Neither called for Masaharta.

Among the northern reeds, the two flankers passed behind a tamarisk at the outer edge of the camp. Masaharta rose behind the first, pulled his head back, and drew the knife across his throat before the man understood that the darkness had hands. He lowered the body rather than let it fall. The second raider turned at the faint scrape. Masaharta drove the knife beneath his ribs and clamped a hand over his mouth, but the man twisted away. His cry tore across the watering place.

Akir was on his feet before the first raider reached the fire. The attacker came forward with a high, ululating war cry that shattered the night. Expecting a sleeping merchant, he found Akir's shield instead. Akir drove the rim into his mouth and cut across his shoulder. Another spear came from the left. Akir turned it aside, but the point opened his upper arm before he trapped the shaft and pulled the attacker within reach.

Bena stayed where Akir had placed him. A raider broke toward the tether line, and Bena met him between two panicking animals. His sword caught the man's forearm. The raider seized a wine jar by its rope and dragged it down between them. Pottery shattered, and wine flooded the sand.

Menna woke beneath his donkey's hooves. The jenny reared while two other donkeys threatened to tear the tether line loose. He rolled clear, caught the rope, and shouted her name as though anger could overcome terror.

Penthu rose without remembering where he was. A raider came through the smoke and slashed at him. Penthu threw one hand before his face. The blade cut across the back of it instead of opening his throat, and he fell backward over the bundle of dates he had saved for home.

Nakht had his writing case in both hands before he had his senses. He saw Penthu fall, dropped the case, and drove his shoulder into the attacker's hips. They went down beside the fire while Penthu clawed for his knife.

Sennefer came up with a staff used for testing loads. He swung it two-handed into the raider's temple before the man could rise from Nakht. The blow did not kill him, but it turned his legs useless. Penthu stared at the man twitching near his feet.

"Bind your hand," Sennefer shouted. "You can be frightened after Memphis."

Near the reeds, Masaharta wrenched his knife free as the wounded flanker collapsed. One reserve man was already retreating. Masaharta threw his spear, but it passed wide of the man's back. The raider did not wait for another.

Akir pulled his opponent closer and struck him across the face with the pommel. The man folded. Another raider seized Nakht's abandoned writing case and ran.

"Let him take it!" Nakht shouted.

Then he understood what he had said and looked briefly stricken. Bena drove the man at the tether line away, but stopped to help Menna secure the donkeys rather than pursue him.

The fight ended without anyone announcing it. Four raiders fled. Masaharta started after them, then stopped when Akir called his name.

Four attackers remained behind. One lay dead in the reeds, another had died with Masaharta's knife beneath his ribs, the man Sennefer had struck breathed shallowly beside the fire, and the spearman Akir had beaten lay unconscious near the

ashes. The raider Akir had cut had fled with the other three, leaving a trail of blood toward the desert.

Menna and Bena calmed the animals. Nakht recovered his writing case from where the fleeing man had dropped it and stared at the wine soaking into the sand. "One jar," he said, almost to himself. Then he looked at Penthu's bleeding hand and seemed ashamed of the thought. "Only one jar."

The cut was long but not deep. Sennefer bound it while Penthu insisted it did not hurt. The dates meant for his family lay crushed in the sand. Menna found three still clean and returned them without comment.

Akir washed the cut on his own arm and then crossed to Masaharta. "You disappeared from your watch."

Masaharta wiped his knife on the dead man's hide. "I was watching."

"Where?" Akir asked. "From the reeds?"

"That was where the men worth watching had gone," Masaharta answered.

Akir looked toward the bodies, then toward the darkness that had swallowed the survivors. "Next time, wake me."

Masaharta's pale eyes moved to the blood on Akir's arm. "If I had woken you, they might have known we had seen them."

Bena laughed once, more from relief than humor. Akir turned toward him, and the sound died.

Masaharta glanced at the broken wine jar. "Sennefer will charge them for that."

"I will charge you," Sennefer said. "You are the one who said the watering place was empty."

Masaharta looked toward the dark road. "It was empty when we arrived. Keeping the roads clear is Egypt's responsibility."

No one answered. Beyond the watering place lay country the crown still named in decrees and guarded mostly in

memory. The attackers were gone, but the darkness remained full of places from which they might return.

They fed the fire until dawn, posted two men at every watch, and slept no more. When the eastern sky began to pale, the desert released the shapes of low ridges and distant tracks. Somewhere beyond them lay the Black Land, the pyramids, the crowded quays, and Memphis behind its white walls. One more day, Sennefer told them. If the animals held their pace, moonrise would find them beneath Ptah's protection.

Akir looked east while Menna brought the first donkey to its feet. The road ahead was empty. That no longer meant it was safe.



The sun hung low above Memphis, and the Nile burned beneath it like a river of molten copper. Where the flood had pulled back, black mounds of earth rose from the water, small islands of beginning in the river's shine. Beyond the green edge of the floodplain, the pyramids of Giza caught the last fire of Ra, their ancient forms rising from the desert like the bones of creation itself. More than thirteen centuries old, worn by wind and time yet still commanding awe, they stood as relics of an Egypt that had once mastered eternity, an age that raised mountains for the dead and crowned them with gold. Below them, the Sphinx kept its silent vigil, its lion's body emerging from wind-piled sand, its human face turned forever toward the Nile and the living world. Dynasties had risen and fallen beneath its gaze. Kings had come seeking eternity and left as dust. Yet it endured, watching as it had through every reign before theirs.

Irsu stood on the balcony of the palace of Merneptah, both hands resting upon the limestone rail, ruling from a royal house built by the son of Ramesses the Great as though inheritance were only another thing weak men failed to defend. Gold rings